



A t-storm around 86/72 • Tomorrow: Breezy 80/67 B18

Democracy Dies in Darkness

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D.C. data on crime faces DOJ inquiry

Administration alleges police warped numbers to make rates appear low

BY PERRY STEIN AND EMILY DAVIES

The Justice Department is investigating whether D.C. police manipulated data to make crime rates appear lower, escalating tensions between the Trump administration and local officials who have repeatedly cited drops in violent crime to protest the need for a federal takeover of law enforcement.

The criminal probe — being run out of the D.C. federal prosecutor’s office, led by U.S. Attorney Jeanine Pirro — is expected to examine the actions of multiple police officials, according to three people familiar with the investigation, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss private deliberations.

“D.C. gave Fake Crime numbers in order to create a false illusion of safety,” President Donald Trump wrote on social media Monday night, confirming the existence of the probe.

“This is a very bad and dangerous thing to do, and they are under serious investigation for so doing!” Trump continued. “Until 4 days ago, Washington, D.C., was the most unsafe ‘city’ in the United States, and perhaps the World. Now, in just a short period of time, it is perhaps the safest, and getting better every single hour!”

SEE CRIME ON A5

No details: Amid uptick in arrests, information is lacking. B13



ED RAM/ FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Larisa, 54, second from right, and other family members gather Sunday to cool off from the heat at a small lake in Slovyansk in eastern Ukraine. The family had evacuated Slovyansk earlier in the war but returned a year later, when a Russian takeover felt less imminent.

Donbas hangs on amid uncertain fate

BY SIOBHÁN O’GRADY AND SERHII KOROLCHUK

DONETSK REGION, UKRAINE — When President Donald Trump hosted Russian President Vladimir Putin in Alaska last week, Oleksandr Bulka, 35, had high hopes the talks would result in at least a partial ceasefire to halt Russian air attacks on Ukrainian civilians like him.

The next morning, he awoke with his legs crushed under the rubble of his apartment in the eastern town of Bilozerske. A Russian glide bomb had smashed into a neighboring building, sending a shock wave toward him. He dragged himself down-

As Russia bargains for their land, many reject exchanging it for peace

stairs, where medics rushed him to a hospital in Kramatorsk, the fortified Ukrainian city that Russia still hopes to seize.

Moscow is intensifying its air assault on Ukrainian civilians along this stretch of the eastern front, in a brutal show of determination to take their territory whether through military force or negotiations — even as Kyiv puts up a fierce resistance on

both counts.

Spirits in Ukraine were slightly bolstered by Monday’s summit in Washington, where Trump warmly welcomed Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky and his European supporters, displaying openness to the security guarantees Kyiv needs.

The next steps could include direct meetings between Zelensky and Putin, although Moscow has not fully accepted that idea and major differences remain over Russian demands for territory. The Kremlin is also likely to be threatened by the suggested security guarantees for Kyiv, which stop short of NATO inclusion but would offer pledges of

defense similar to those for member countries.

The Russian onslaught comes after Putin floated a proposal to Trump that he would end the war if Ukraine ceded all of the eastern Donbas area, which includes Kramatorsk, Bilozerske and other cities that make up the 30 percent of the Donetsk region that Russia has for years failed to capture. (Luhansk, the other region in Donbas, is under near-total Russian control.) Russia made some ground gains in a surprise assault last week, but Ukraine has since stemmed the advance, calming fears of a full collapse along the eastern front.

SEE DONBAS ON A8

Peace talks’ outlook fogs up

KREMLIN DIVERGES FROM UPBEAT U.S.

White House says Putin agreed to meet Zelensky

BY PATRICK SVITEK AND CAT ZAKRZEWSKI

The White House said Tuesday that Russian President Vladimir Putin agreed to meet with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky, projecting confidence that a summit between the warring leaders is on track even as the Kremlin was noncommittal about a meeting.

The Russian president agreed during a call with President Donald Trump to “begin the next phase of the peace process — a meeting between President Putin and President Zelensky,” White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt said Tuesday.

Earlier in the day, Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov played down expectations of a swift bilateral meeting with Zelensky. Russia has not rejected bilateral or trilateral meetings, “but any contacts involving the heads of state need to be thoroughly prepared,” Lavrov said.

Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov did not immediately

SEE UKRAINE ON A12

Congress: Republicans take a harder line on talks with Putin. A9

Europe: Leaders hail Trump’s vow for Ukraine security safeguards. A9

Pirro won’t bring cases on carrying long guns

She says D.C.’s blanket ban is in violation of Supreme Court rulings

BY SALVADOR RIZZO

Federal prosecutors in D.C. have been instructed not to seek felony charges against people who are carrying rifles or shotguns in the nation’s capital, regardless of the strength of the evidence, according to U.S. Attorney Jeanine Pirro and an email reviewed by The Washington Post.

The new policy, which Pirro said was crafted by the Justice Department and its solicitor general, marks a break with past practice. Prosecutors have used the D.C. law at issue — which prohibits carrying shotguns or rifles, with narrow exceptions for permit-holders — to charge defendants in several high-profile incidents, including a 2019 shotgun attack in Northeast Washington and the “Pizzagate” shooter who targeted a restaurant in the city’s Chevy Chase neighborhood with an AR-15 rifle and a handgun in 2016.

The shift comes at an unexpected time — just as the Trump

SEE PIRRO ON A6

Eastern Seaboard braces for Hurricane Erin to pass



ROBERT MILLER/THE WASHINGTON POST

Erin will reach just over 200 miles off the coast of North Carolina on Thursday.

Even though the storm won’t make landfall, it’s expected to bring flooding,

dangerous waves and rip currents to a large swath of the East Coast. Story, A18

Brazilian judge, facing Trump’s ire, is steadfast

Alexandre de Moraes says he won’t ‘back off’ as U.S. levies penalties on him and his country

BY TERENCE MCCOY AND MARINA DIAS

BRASÍLIA — The judge had allowed himself a moment to relax. His beloved Corinthians soccer team was playing on television. The game wasn’t particularly good, he said, but it was a useful distraction — from the American sanctions against him, the taunts from Elon Musk and the U.S. tariffs imposed on Brazil by President Donald Trump in direct response to his work.

The brief reverie of Federal Supreme Court Justice Alexandre de Moraes was not to last. His phone began lighting up with messages.

Jair Bolsonaro, the former Brazilian president awaiting trial next month on charges of leading a violent coup plot, appeared to have disobeyed an order by Moraes barring him from social me-

dia. The judge took immediate action, unilaterally ordering the country’s most popular conservative politician to be placed under house arrest.

“The court will not allow the defendant to make a fool of it,” Moraes wrote in his Aug. 4 decision.

The episode, recounted by the judge in an exclusive interview with The Washington Post, was emblematic of Moraes’s rules of engagement, which have governed his conduct throughout a career marked by high-stakes battles with powerful politicians and businessmen: Never give in. Always escalate.

As a young prosecutor, he took on São Paulo city hall in a far-reaching corruption probe. As a justice on Brazil’s Federal Supreme Court, he has clashed with

SEE BRAZIL ON A13

7-year-old U.S. citizen is stuck in China as father stands trial for his art

BY CHRISTIAN SHEPHERD AND LYRIC LI

This was meant to be the summer Gao Jia finished first grade in New York and spent his school break playing with friends near his home on Long Island or drawing with his father, Gao Zhen, a Chinese artist known for his irrev-

erent caricatures of Mao Zedong, the founder of modern China.

Instead, the outgoing 7-year-old U.S. citizen with spiky hair and a mischievous grin has been stuck in China for nearly a year while his father stands trial on charges relating to artwork produced long before his son was born.

Jia has been trapped by the

system of exit bans that Chinese law enforcement has used with increasing regularity since Xi Jinping became China’s leader in 2012. The exit bans are used to prevent dissidents and their families from leaving the country and to pressure them into silence, according to human rights groups.

The family’s difficulties began a

year ago when Gao, 69, was arrested while visiting family in China. Authorities raided the studio he kept on the outskirts of Beijing and confiscated dozens of sketches and sculptures.

The U.S. permanent resident has been held in detention for a year on charges of “slandering heroes and martyrs.” Prosecutors

claim satirical statues he made nearly 20 years ago damaged Mao’s reputation.

His family soon discovered they too were trapped. When his wife, Zhao Yaliang, tried to return to their home in New York with their son last September, she was told by immigration authorities she

SEE CHINA ON A12

IN THE NEWS

Civil service questionnaire A congressionally mandated survey of federal workers has been canceled by the Trump administration. A4

A gentler release “Water cremation,” an increasingly popular method of managing human remains that is greener than the traditional form, has arrived in Maryland. B13

THE NATION A pediatric group and the HHS chief clashed over coronavirus shots for young children. A2 A Democrat slept at the Texas Capitol to protest an order requiring police monitoring. A3

THE WORLD In the wake of the most severe confrontation between India and Pakistan in decades, the nations have undergone a striking role reversal in their relations with the United States. A7

THE ECONOMY The British government has dropped its user-data demand targeting Apple, Director of National Intelligence Tulsi Gabbard said. A14 Intel, struggling after falling behind in AI, will receive an investment of \$2 billion from Japan’s SoftBank. A18

STYLE Outrageously luxurious dorm room makeovers are all the rage, at least on TikTok. B1

SPORTS John Wall announced his retirement from the NBA, but the former Wizards star will remain close to the game. B7

THE REGION Maryland lawmakers confronted the interim head of Immigration and Customs Enforcement’s Baltimore field office, questioning tactics. B13

FOOD Learn how to churn out creamy batches of homemade ice cream without, well, churning. E1

BUSINESS NEWS.....A14 COMICS.....B4 OBITUARIES.....B17 OPINION PAGES.....A15 TELEVISION.....B6 WORLD NEWS.....A7

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